

- i) Double clicking in empty space in the projects panel. This will open a file explorer and you can choose the element you want to import from there.
- ii) Opening a folder separately and then just dragging and dropping from the folder to the project panel.

Once your elements have been imported in After Effects, the next step is to include it as a composition. Again, there are a couple of ways to do this, you can either drag it and drop it in into the composition panel or you can do the same into the timeline panel. Both of these will get the job done. Elements can also be renamed by selecting it and hitting the Enter button. (Note: Double clicking the element will create a separate layer in the Composition panel, so we need to be wary of that).

*TIP: You can import folders as a whole if you already have them organised outside of AE instead of individually bringing in each element and putting it into a folder inside AE. Regardless of the type of file, the procedure is uniform throughout.*

Once they have been moved to the timeline panel, it is of particular value to note the length of the time bar of each unique element. For elements like videos, the length of the time bar is determined directly by the length of the video (a 30 second video will have a 30 second duration in the timeline panel) but for elements like pictures or illustrations (imported from Adobe Illustrate), the time bars span the length of the timeline panel, because these elements by default are not time bound and because of that they have an indefinite duration which can be cut down as per our demands.

Once you import something into After Effects, it might not seem like much of a hassle when you only have a few elements to play around with but on more complicated projects, you could be working with 100s of different elements, layers and compositions which is a very tasking number. To prepare for situations like this in the future, it makes for good practice to neatly label and organise every single folder you're working with. While this may seem like overkill in the beginning, it is a habit that you will be thankful for later.

One of the most efficient ways you can do this is by having 2 main folders – one for assets and one for pre-compositions. The assets folder will contain every single element that you will be working with individually. So it makes even more sense to further create sub folders with different categories of elements like images, videos, audio, illustrations, etc. To take this a step further, you can create further sub folders to hold all files of a particular data type. So, in case of images, you will have a group of sub folders which say .png, .jpg, etc. In the case of videos, you will have .mp4, .wav, etc. Similarly,